Personal, Relevant Background, and Future Goals Statement

The day my research assistant burst into the lab, wide-eyed with disbelief, I shared their rush of shock and exhilaration. I was studying whether people would comply with intrusive search requests, and participants were agreeing to hand over their unlocked phones without hesitation—despite 64% of people previously saying they would never give a stranger their phone. The striking difference between what people say and what they actually do captures what draws me to social psychology: understanding how people make decisions when context, culture, and personal variability collide. The thrill of exploring ambiguity in human judgment led me to the one institution that cannot afford a gray area: the justice system. In my upcoming doctoral career, I will apply psychological science to the legal system, using biopsychosocial methods to examine where legal assumptions about rational judgment diverge from the realities of human psychology, with the goal of creating a more effective and trustworthy justice system.

Intellectual Merit

My research examines how people navigate gray areas in social judgment—whether in close relationships or in the courtroom. I've combined behavioral, physiological, and social psychological methods to understand the realities of human judgment to improve fairness and trust in the legal system.

Undergraduate Research Coordinator. I first began exploring social psychology during my freshman year at the University of Michigan (U-M), working as a research assistant in Dr. Amie Gordon's Well-Being, Health, and Interpersonal Relationships Lab. Dr. Gordon selected me as a study coordinator to launch a large-scale longitudinal study examining how shared or unshared relational stress affects romantic couples' relationship quality. Over the course of the year, I designed a recruitment strategy to bring 436 participants (218 romantic couples) into the lab, ran in-person lab sessions that included the Trier Social Stress Test (i.e., a stress-induction paradigm), collected biopsychological data (i.e., continuous heart rate, saliva for hormonal analyses, blood pressure), and guided couples through a subsequent two-week daily diary. I also coordinated data collection for a year following the dyad's initial lab session to track changes in relational quality over time. This study tested whether concurrent stress in close relationships negatively impacts relationship quality more than unshared stress. These early projects taught me that even in our most intimate relationships, human behavior is ambiguous—a lesson that continues to shape how I study judgment and decision-making.

Undergraduate Lab Manager. After my year as study coordinator, I obtained the lab manager position in Dr. Gordon's lab, a role typically reserved for post-baccalaureate candidates. This role was the lab's sole paid position and I was the only undergraduate manager in our department. Being the only undergraduate in many of our research meetings gave me early invaluable experience collaborating with senior researchers.

I began to work closely with Dr. Robin Edelstein, director of the Relationships & Hormones Lab at Michigan, whose work blends social psychological theories with neuroendocrinological research methods. In a collaboration between the Gordon and Edelstein labs, I helped launch a pilot study that gave romantic couples an infant simulator (i.e., fake baby) to take home for the weekend and track their relational, hormonal, and emotional changes. I ran independent analyses to investigate how first-time parenthood affected division of labor between partners. I found that sleep disruption led individuals with lower expectations of equality to be more likely to report an unequal distribution of childcare. I presented my findings as a **first-author poster, supported by an awarded travel grant**, at the 2023 *Society for Personality and Social Psychology* (*SPSP*) national conference.

Throughout the concurrent stress and infant simulator studies, I oversaw the collection and hormonal analysis of over 2,000 saliva samples. I led our team through working in the wet laboratory for the first time by learning and training others on an enzyme-linked immunosorbent assay technique. These assays allowed us to examine how experiences of concurrent stress and first-time parenthood affect couples on a biological level. In the infant simulator study, we found that couples with more positive expectations about parenting showed decreases in testosterone when caring for the infant simulator, suggesting that an optimistic approach helps parents adapt more readily to a nurturing role. **I contributed as an author on the manuscript that is currently under review**[1].

Senior Honors Thesis. I was motivated to use the U-M thesis program as an opportunity to apply psychological research to the legal setting, where ambiguous social behavior meets a rigid, structured set of rules. Previous research on high-stakes compliance requests revealed a consistent pattern: Though most people *think* they wouldn't agree to an intrusive consent request, the majority overwhelmingly *do*, creating consequences for compliance under pressure. However, little research had examined how the presence of others shapes decision outcomes in this context, so **I designed two experimental studies** to test how intentions and behavior when facing a phone search request differ when participants were alone versus in the presence of a close friend. I trained five research assistants on the paradigm and ran 466 participants through the two studies during my senior year. Though people expected they would be more likely to comply when seated with a close friend, the overwhelming majority in both conditions handed over their phone—97% when with a friend, and 100% when seated alone. I was **awarded the faculty-nominated Pillsbury Award for best thesis in my major and graduated with Highest Honors**. I **presented these findings as a talk** at the 2025 *SPSP* legal psychology pre-conference and as a poster at both the 2024 *SPSP* national conference and the 2024 *American Psychology-Law Society* (*AP-LS*) conference. I am preparing this work to **submit as a first-authored paper**[2].

This project gave me the opportunity to design and lead my own research project, which further prepared me to pursue graduate studies. Seeing a project from beginning to end taught me the value of scientific research to address real-world problems and gave me an invaluable base of knowledge to build on in my career. This confirmed my love for studying social psychology and using a variety of methods to answer questions about how we interact with others in the world. Following this work, I was eager to conduct post-baccalaureate research to directly examine how psychological judgments apply to external institutions like the law.

Post-Baccalaureate Lab Manager. I earned a lab manager position in Dr. Kurt Gray's Deepest Beliefs Lab at The University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill and subsequently at The Ohio State University, where I study how moral judgments can inform legal issues. Moral judgments lie at the center of legal conflicts and provide an opportunity to study how gray areas of human reasoning conflict with the rigid expectations set by the law.

In an ongoing first-authored project, I am investigating whether personal fear of crime paradoxically makes people more likely to blame victims of crime. In an initial study, participants read vignettes about crimes of varying severity (e.g., pickpocketing vs. assault) and rated the blameworthiness of the perpetrator and the victim. I found that those who feared crime more were more likely to blame victims, potentially to resolve their own cognitive dissonance (e.g., "They didn't protect themselves—but I'd be prepared"). My NSF GRFP research proposal builds directly on these findings to explore if this effect generalizes and is explained by crime reporting that induces fear. I have presented these findings as first-author at the 2025 *SPSP* conference and the 2025 *AP-LS* conference. I aim to use this research to design interventions to reduce victim blaming by targeting how crime is reported at a national level.

Broader Impacts

My goal as a scientist is to use psychology not only to understand people, but to improve the systems that shape their lives. I believe science should be accessible, transparent, and collaborative. My experiences have equipped me with the skills necessary to conduct effective research and I am prepared to translate my findings to make the justice system more effective and fair.

Building Partnerships with Industry. Psychological science must reach beyond academia to influence legal and policy systems. Alongside my empirical work with Dr. Gray, I recently had a **second-author review article accepted in a policy journal**[4] to provide evidence-based psychological solutions for the judicial system, titled "The Psychology of Victimhood in the Law". We propose that psychological perceptions of victimhood, which tend to be biased, intuitive, and hard to change, differ from legal expectations. The mismatch between our mind's perceptions of victimhood and the law's execution of victimhood leads to distrust of the law, denials of true suffering, and continued condemnation of the exonerated. My work directly reaches policymakers directly through this journal and educates them on how to use psychological findings to improve the judicial process.

Public Engagement and Scientific Literacy. Beyond communication within the scientific community, I have a passion for making scientific discoveries available and interpretable by a broader audience. I currently **co-author the Substack newsletter** *Moral Understanding: The Science of What Divides and Unites Us* with Dr. Kurt Gray. I have contributed to twelve pieces on how science applies to real-world topics with an average of 2.5k readers per piece. For example, in one post, we discussed how public responses to assassinations differ based on ideology due to moral typecasting. Each essay connects psychological science to current issues in law, morality, and policy. Additionally, upon joining Dr. Gray's lab, I created an X/Twitter account to share this work with the broader community. I also recently **co-organized the inaugural Science to Impact conference** at The Ohio State University, which trained researchers on how to best share scientific findings with the general public. I brought together eight award-winning speakers who covered all aspects of scientific communication—social media, op-ed pieces, podcasts, and books. By facilitating these exchanges between academia and broader audiences, I increased collaboration between academia and industry.

Mentoring the Next Generation of Scientists. I have had many great experiences with mentors in psychology, which makes me passionate about being an effective mentor myself. I began mentoring undergraduate students in research when I was an undergraduate lab manager. I've co-authored eight presentations with undergraduate research assistants, **three of which received awards for excellence in research and presentation**.

In my first month as a lab manager in Dr. Gray's lab, an undergraduate senior approached me about the possibility of mentoring her undergraduate thesis. I met with her weekly to design the project and **served on her thesis committee, which received an Honors Distinction**. The thesis investigated whether lay perceptions of self-defense in battered women cases align with the legal standard, which states that self-defense can only be used if there is an imminent and life-threatening event. We asked whether laypeople find it permissible for historically abused spouses to use force against their partner even if there is not an imminent threat. We found that laypeople perceive self-defense to be more permissible when it is preceded by a history of abuse, but not when it is premeditated. When given the legal standard, participants did not change their original opinion on whether the scenario was considered "self-defense," suggesting that jurors may judge cases based on their lay intuitions rather than formal legal instructions. In order to improve trust in the legal system, there is a real need for research in legal psychology to examine how we can better align legal standards with our psychology.

Future Goals. My experiences have taught me that **science is most powerful when it leaves the lab**. I plan to carry these lessons forward in graduate school by continuing to mentor students, engage in public-facing research, and collaborate with interdisciplinary partners to help psychological science inform real-world systems. My long-term goal is to lead a research laboratory in collaboration with legal experts to apply psychological insights toward improving the justice system. Recently, I have been in contact with Dr. X at X University about receiving graduate school mentorship in their lab. Their program uniquely applies morality to the legal system, providing a strong foundation for me to conduct this work. I plan to continue my goals of making psychological science accessible and using research to promote a fair justice system by collaborating with X program to translate my findings into conversations on legal reform and victim support. X's emphasis on connecting morality and law—and the breadth of collaborators like Dr. Y and Dr. Z—makes it an ideal environment to conduct research on moral psychology and legal reform.

The NSF GRFP will allow me to integrate high-impact experimental research with policy and industry collaborations during my graduate training. Since both science and the law are often difficult for the public to interpret, I am committed to bridging that gap through science communication and outreach. An NSF fellowship would make it possible to pursue this integrated mission—advancing rigorous research while ensuring insights reach the broader public it serves.

References. [1]Brandon, R., From, A., Reynaga, M., **Devine, H.**, Gordon, A. M., & Edelstein, R. S. *Under review*. [2]**Devine, H.**, Meyer, M., & Gordon, A. M. *In prep*. [3]Walster, E. (1966). *JPSP*. [4]Gray, K., **Devine, H.**, & Kubin, E. (in press). *Policy Insights from the Behavioral and Brain Sciences*.

Graduate Research Plan Statement

Reducing Victim-Blaming by Targeting Fear of Crime

Being a victim of crime is already devastating, but recovering becomes far more difficult when you are blamed for what happened. Victim-blaming makes victims less likely to seek help and more likely to experience adverse mental health consequences like depression or PTSD[1]. There are also systemic consequences: Jurors view victims as less credible, police pursue fewer cases, and survivors withdraw entirely from the system[1]. Shifting responsibility from offenders to victims diverts attention from larger issues that fuel crime, thereby reinforcing unsafe conditions for everyone. Despite public movements meant to promote empathy for victims (e.g., #MeToo), harmful victim-blaming attitudes persist. Traditional theories of victim-blaming highlight the influence of prejudicial beliefs, such as sexism or just-world thinking[2]. These attitudes matter, but even those who reject prejudice still often blame victims. My proposal tests an alternative hypothesis: **victim-blaming is an adaptive, logical response to fear.**

Although national crime rates have steadily declined, anxiety about crime has hit record highs[3]. Meanwhile, crime-related entertainment and news have exploded in popularity[4]. People are investing in fear: Home security sales have surged, and over half of U.S. homes now have at least one security camera[5]. This fear shapes how we think about victims. Defensive attribution theory[6] (DAT) suggests that when people see victims who are demographically similar to themselves, the threat of victimization causes them to blame the victim to restore personal control. While DAT describes *how* people manage perceived threats (i.e., blaming victims), it does not fully address *what* triggers a threat response beyond similarity. People also blame victims they are not similar to. I propose that **fear activates defensive victim-blaming: Those who feel unsafe hold victims responsible to increase personal control.**

If victim-blaming is a natural response to fear, we must understand what *causes* overpronounced fear. I propose that the media is a key driver of perceptions of crime. Most crime coverage is episodic—stories centered on vivid individual cases—which heightens fear and blame, in contrast to thematic coverage that focuses on systemic causes and reduces both[7]. True crime and news outlets that rely on episodic storytelling create a constant sense of "likely" threat by spotlighting sensationalized, unpredictable acts of harm. This framing increases fear, which triggers defensive victim-blaming.

Pilot Study. To test this theory, I conducted a pilot study (N = 228; Figure 1) examining whether fearing crime is associated with victim-blaming. I found a strong relationship between fearing crime and blaming victims of crime (b_{avg} = 0.19, range = 0.11–0.25, ps <= .02). Those most afraid of crime were more likely to blame victims, rather than perpetrators. This counters intuitions of blame and prejudice theories but is directly predicted by fear-driven defensive victim-blaming.

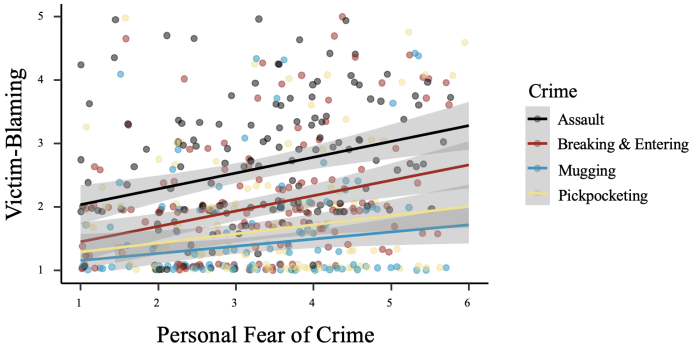


Figure 1. Fearing crime was significantly positively associated with victim-blaming attitudes.

Overview of Studies. Given that fear of crime is strongly associated with victim-blaming rhetoric, the goal of this work is to test whether fear is a direct cause of victim blaming and understand what causes widespread fear.

Study 1. Purpose. Establish ecological validity and test whether fear of crime predicts victim-blaming attitudes across demographics and media habits. **Method.** A nationally representative online sample of American adults (N = 500) will complete measures of fear of crime, victim-blaming, just-world beliefs, and sexist attitudes, along with self-reported crime-related media consumption (e.g., true crime podcasts, television). Participants will rate blame for victims and offenders across common crimes from the U.S. Department of Justice. I will enter fear of crime and prejudice as simultaneous predictors in a regression model to examine whether each predicts victim blaming, controlling for the other. **Expected Results.** Fear of crime will better

predict victim-blaming than prejudicial attitudes. Those who consume crime-related media are expected to report higher fear of crime and victim-blaming.

Study 2. Purpose. Test whether viewing episodic crime coverage increases victim-blaming and whether this effect is explained by increased fear. **Method.** In an online experiment, participants (N = 625; powered for 80% to detect d = .25 between framing conditions) will be randomly assigned to read one of three brief news stories: (1) a crime story framed *episodically* (vivid, victim-focused) (2) the same story framed *thematically* (contextualized with crime statistics and broader causes), or (3) a neutral *control* story about local weather. Before reading, participants will report demographic information and complete a just-world belief measure. After exposure, participants will rate their fear of crime, perceived control, and blameworthiness of the victim and the perpetrator in the story. They will then evaluate short additional crime scenarios (from U.S. Department of Justice statistics), allowing us to assess whether victim-blaming generalizes across contexts. Analyses will compare victim-blaming across conditions using regression models and test whether fear mediates the relationship between media exposure and victim-blaming. **Expected Results.** Episodic stories are expected to heighten fear and victim-blaming relative to thematic and control conditions. I hypothesize fear will mediate the relationship between episodic framing and victim-blaming, providing evidence that fear—beyond demographic similarity or just-world beliefs—activates defensive attributions towards victims.

Study 3. Purpose. Test whether repeated exposure to accurate crime statistics reduces fear of crime and downstream victim-blaming. **Method.** In a two-week longitudinal experiment, participants (N = 500; powered for 80% to detect d = .25 between conditions) will be randomly assigned to receive three short text messages per week that either (1) present accurate crime statistics emphasizing long-term declines in victimization or (2) present weather statistics matched for length and phrasing. At the beginning of the study, midpoint (1-week), and end (2-week), participants will report their fear of crime, victim-blaming attitudes, and prejudicial beliefs. I will use mixed-effects models to compare changes in fear and victim-blaming over time across conditions. **Expected Results.** Participants who receive crime statistics are expected to show decreased victim-blaming attitudes at the mid and endpoint relative to the neutral control. Reductions in fear are expected to mediate this effect, demonstrating that lowering perceived personal risk of victimization can weaken fear-driven victim-blaming.

Intellectual Merit

My proposal examines how fear of becoming a victim causes people to blame victims to feel safer, making two key contributions to the scientific understanding of victim-blaming. First, I reframe victim-blaming as a potentially adaptive—though socially harmful—response to fear and perceived vulnerability, rather than a prejudicial or moral failure. This approach aligns with broader movements in social psychology to reinterpret negative social behaviors as logical responses to perceived threats. Second, this project revives and extends defensive attribution theory by identifying fear as its central cause, showing that victim-blaming can emerge even without similarity to a victim or negative attitudes. Together, this creates a more complete theory of how fear and perceived control shape moral judgments.

Broader Impacts

I plan to translate these findings into practice by developing a communication toolkit for journalists and legal educators that presents evidence-based ways to communicate crime without amplifying fear or blame. My findings will create sample crime reporting templates that apply my research to real-world messaging. In addition, prior work shows that vivid emotional evidence increases punitive jury verdicts[8], and my work suggests this may occur because such material heightens personal fear. By testing alternative framing techniques, I aim to provide empirically grounded recommendations for how crime can be presented in court to reduce fear-based blame while preserving informativeness. Together, these contributions will make public communication and legal decision-making more accurate, humane, and aligned with psychological science.

References. [1]Campbell, R., et al. (2009). *Trauma, Violence, & Abuse*. [2]van den Bos, K. & Maas, M. (2009). *PSPB*. [3]Saad, L. (2023). *Gallup*. [4]Naseer, S. & St. Aubin, C. (2023). *Pew Research*. [5]Gabriele, R. (2025). *2025 Home Security Market Report*. [6]Walster, E. (1966). *JPSP*. [7]Gilliam, F. & Iyengar, S. (2000). *American Journal of Political Science*. [8]Salerno, J. (2021). *Annual Review of Law and Social Science*.